

Development as Myth and Religion — Detailed Study Notes

Sources: Gilbert Rist, *The History of Development*, Ch. 1 ("Definitions of Development") · Wolfgang Sachs, Introduction to *The Development Dictionary*

Note on approach: Every technical/social-science term is defined in plain language the first time it appears, with an everyday or CS-flavored analogy where it helps. Bolded terms are glossary-worthy — there's a full glossary at the end for quick revision.

PART 1 — Gilbert Rist: "Definitions of Development"

0. What the chapter is trying to do

Sociology is the scientific study of society — how groups of people organize, behave, and believe things collectively (the same way computer science studies computation, sociology studies "the social"). Rist is a sociologist, and this chapter asks a deceptively simple question: *what does "development" actually mean?* His answer, built using **Émile Durkheim's** methodology (more on Durkheim below), is that development isn't a good, natural, or scientific process — it's better understood as a **secular religion**: a belief system that behaves like a religion (dogma, rituals, priests, blind faith) even though it claims to be rational and non-religious ("secular" = not connected to religion). He also calls it **entropic** and **commodifying** — two words unpacked in detail in Section 3.

1. Conventional Thinking and Existing Definitions

In exact sciences — Rist's examples are mathematics, psychology, photography — a word like "development" has one precise, agreed meaning (e.g., in photography, "developing" film is a specific chemical process). But in everyday political/social language, "development" gets loaded with vague, feel-good ideals: progress, well-being, growth, social justice. Nobody quite agrees what it means, yet everyone acts like they do.

Rist gives three real definitions used by influential institutions to show this vagueness:

The *Petit Robert Dictionary* (1987): A major French dictionary defined a "developing country" simply as one whose economy hasn't yet reached the level of North America or Western Europe. Rist points out this is really just a polite replacement word (a **euphemism** — a milder-sounding substitute for something with a harsher name) for the more blatant word "underdeveloped."

The South Commission Report (1987), chaired by Julius Nyerere (former president of Tanzania and a leading Third-World statesman): Defined development as an **endogenous** (self-generated, coming from within a society rather than imposed from outside) process that lets people realize their potential, build dignity, gain political freedom, and escape exploitation. This is an idealistic, humanist definition.

The UNDP Human Development Report (1991) (UNDP = United Nations Development Programme): Defined development as enlarging the range of human choices — democratic participation, education, health, income, a clean environment.

Rist's critique of all three: they sound nice, but they share hidden assumptions and structural problems:

Social evolutionism: the 19th-century idea (loosely, and wrongly, borrowed from Darwin's biological evolution) that human societies pass through fixed stages from "primitive" to "advanced," with Western industrial society sitting at the top of the ladder. Under this assumption, "developing" a country secretly means making it more like the West — "catching up."

Individualism: treating the individual person (rather than the family, community, or collective) as the basic unit whose "potential" or "choices" need expanding. This is itself a culturally specific (largely Western) way of framing human worth.

Economism: the reduction of "progress" to economic growth or income — treating GDP-style numbers as the main or only real measure of whether a society is doing well.

Normative vs. Descriptive statements: A **normative** statement says what *ought* to happen (a value judgment, a wish, a goal) — e.g., "people should have more freedom." A **descriptive** statement says what actually *is* happening, based on observation — e.g., "in country X, income has risen by 3%." All three definitions above are normative: they're wish-lists, not observations of reality. That makes them definitions of an *ideal*, not of a *thing that exists and can be studied objectively*.

Use of intensifiers: Words like "*more* democratic" or "*more* participatory" are **intensifiers** — words that describe an increase or a comparison rather than a fixed, observable state. If you say a country needs to be "more democratic," you're really just saying it currently lacks democracy — you're describing an absence, not defining a positive reality. This is a subtle logical trick: it sounds like a definition, but it's actually just a complaint dressed up as a goal.

2. A Methodological Word of Caution (Durkheimian Criteria)

Émile Durkheim (1858–1917) was a French scholar considered one of the founders of sociology as a rigorous discipline. His central methodological rule (from his book *The Rules of Sociological Method*) was: treat **social facts** (beliefs, institutions, customs — anything collectively shared in a society) **as "things"** — meaning, study them the way a natural scientist studies rocks or chemicals: objectively, from the outside, based on what can actually be observed, not based on your own opinions or the explanations people give for their own behavior. This approach is called **positivism** or the **empirical method** — building knowledge strictly from observable, verifiable evidence rather than from theory, intuition, or ideology.

Rist applies this Durkheimian discipline to build a scientific (rather than moralistic) definition of development:

Eliminate preconceptions: Throw out common-sense assumptions and personal value judgments before you start defining something — don't let your own hopes about what development *should* be color your definition of what it *is*.

Focus on external characteristics: Define something only by practices that are *observable from the outside* and common to every instance of it — clear enough that a total outsider (Rist uses the image

of a Martian/alien with no cultural baggage) could point at the world and correctly identify "yes, development is happening here" without needing to share anyone's values or hopes.

Durkheim's twofold requirement for a scientific definition:

It must cover **all** cases of the phenomenon (nothing that's actually "development" should fall outside the definition).

It must include **only** external, observable characteristics (no wishes, hopes, or value judgments smuggled in).

The trap of "Plastic Words": This idea (borrowed from linguist **Uwe Pörksen**, who coined the term) describes words that *sound* scientific and authoritative but have become so stretchy and vague that they can be used to justify almost anything — good or bad. "Development" is a classic plastic word: it can be invoked to justify building a dam *and* to justify opposing one, to justify free trade *and* protectionism, to justify state control *and* privatization. A word that can defend any position defends none — it has become an empty container people pour their own meaning into. (Related idea: a **portmanteau word**, originally a Lewis Carroll term for blending two words into one — like "smog" from "smoke" + "fog" — used loosely here to describe how "development" packs many, even contradictory, meanings into a single term.)

3. The Operational Definition of Development

Having stripped away wishful thinking, Rist proposes what he calls an **operational definition** — one built only from observable practices, that can actually be used ("operated with") to study the world scientifically:

"'Development' consists of a set of practices, sometimes appearing to conflict with one another, which require — for the reproduction of society — the general transformation and destruction of the natural environment and of social relations. Its aim is to increase the production of commodities (goods and services) geared, by way of exchange, to effective demand."

Breaking this down clause by clause:

"A set of practices, sometimes appearing to conflict with one another" This means development is defined by *real, observable actions*, not by any single ideology — and these actions often visibly contradict each other. Examples Rist lists: profit-driven private investment vs. charity-driven NGO aid; trade liberalization (opening up markets) vs. protectionism (shielding domestic industry with tariffs); state nationalization (government taking control of industry) vs. privatization (selling it to private owners); piling up debt vs. debt relief (forgiving it). All of these opposite policies get called "development" — proof that the word doesn't refer to one coherent thing, but to a whole *system of practices*.

"The reproduction of society" The modern global economic system ("world-system") keeps itself running by continually expanding — geographically (into new markets/territories) and structurally (into new areas of life). It pulls in whatever/whoever is useful and abandons whatever/whoever isn't — i.e., it grows by absorbing new resources and discarding what it no longer needs.

"Transformation and destruction of the natural environment"

Entropic: This borrows a concept from physics — **entropy**, from the second law of thermodynamics, describes how, in any closed system, useful/ordered energy naturally and irreversibly degrades into disorder (heat, waste) over time. You can't "unburn" fuel and get the ordered chemical energy back. Rist applies this to industrial production: raw materials (ordered resources) get converted into products, but also into exhaust, waste, and heat that dissipate and can't be recovered — an irreversible one-way process, just like entropy in physics. Industrial "development" replaced **renewable energy sources** (windmills, watermills — power drawn continuously from nature without depleting a stock) with fossil-fuel-powered "**fire machines**" (steam engines, combustion engines) — burning stored, non-renewable energy (coal, oil) that took millions of years to form and can't be replaced on any human timescale. This drive to convert nature into resources keeps expanding — into genetic engineering (patenting living organisms, i.e. treating genetic code itself as ownable property) and into space (claiming **geostationary orbits** — the fixed satellite parking spots directly above the equator — as a resource to be divided up).

"Transformation and destruction of social relations"

Kinship (family/clan bonds) and **gift economies/reciprocity** (systems where people exchange help, food, or goods based on mutual obligation and trust, not money — "I help with your harvest, you help build my roof") get replaced by **wage labor** (working for money paid by an employer) and **commodity exchange** (the rule that goods and services are bought and sold in a market at a price). Market logic even spreads into intimate areas of life: marriage, having children, domestic life, and practices like **surrogate motherhood** / "womb leasing" (paying a woman to carry and bear a child for someone else) — turning relationships and bodies into things that can be priced and traded. Rist connects this to **Adam Smith** (1723–1790, Scottish economist, author of *The Wealth of Nations*, widely called the father of modern economics), who famously argued that the market runs on self-interest rather than kindness: "*We address ourselves, not to their humanity but to their self-love*" (i.e., the butcher sells you meat not out of generosity but because it's profitable for him). Rist's point: modern development doesn't just describe an economic system — it exports this entire *anthropology* (a view of human nature) worldwide, redefining what human beings fundamentally are (self-interested market actors, not people bound by mutual obligation).

"To increase the production of commodities..." This is governed by an unquestioned assumption ("dogma," a belief accepted without proof) that "more is always better." Economic systems are structured so that they *must* keep growing or risk collapse (a business that stops growing is considered "failing," even if it's stable and profitable) — and the ecological costs of that growth (pollution, resource depletion) are treated as **externalities**: costs that fall outside the system's accounting, so nobody "pays" for them directly and they get ignored.

"Geared, by way of exchange, to effective demand"

Effective demand is an economics term for demand that is backed by actual money/purchasing power — as opposed to mere *need*. A starving person with no money has a real *need* for food but no *effective demand* for it in market terms, so the market has no built-in mechanism to feed them. Production only flows toward people who can pay, i.e., who have **solvency** (the ability to pay their debts/afford things).

The intertemporality problem: Markets only register the preferences of people who exist and can bid *today*. Future generations — people not yet born — can't participate in today's market to protect resources for themselves. So non-renewable resources like oil get used up now, with no market mechanism protecting the interests of people who will need them later.

4. Development as the Religion of Modernity

Rist's central, most provocative argument: development survives despite six-plus decades of repeated failure to deliver its promises — and the reason is structural, not accidental. He explains this using Durkheim's **sociology of religion**.

The Religion Analogy (Durkheim): Durkheim argued that even a sociologist who doesn't personally believe in Christianity (an **agnostic**, i.e. someone who neither affirms nor denies religious belief) can still study it *scientifically* — not by evaluating whether its claims about "universal love" are spiritually true, but by observing its external rites and practices (rituals, institutions, social functions). Rist says the same approach should be applied to development: study what it *does* in the real world, not what its supporters *say* it's for.

Migration of the Sacred: Modern society presents itself as **secular** (non-religious, rational, scientific) — but Rist argues that religious-style thinking didn't disappear, it just relocated ("migrated") into supposedly secular ideas like "development," "progress," and "growth." The difference between an **ideology** (a set of political/economic beliefs, like liberalism or socialism, that people are allowed to openly debate and disagree with) and this kind of **collective certainty** is that the latter operates *above* debate — like religious dogma, questioning it isn't treated as a legitimate opinion, but almost as a kind of heresy or naivety.

"Floating Propositions": Statements that are widely accepted as self-evidently true and repeated constantly, without ever actually being proven — e.g., "economic recovery will solve unemployment," "technology will solve all problems." Rist compares these to how paper money used to be **backed by gold reserves** (a government promise that your paper note could be exchanged for a fixed amount of real gold). Just as that backing was eventually abandoned (modern currency isn't backed by gold at all — its value rests purely on collective trust), these "floating propositions" aren't really backed by proof either — their authority rests purely on being widely believed.

Rituals & Modern Priesthood:

Rituals: World's fairs, political summits, **G-8 meetings** (a forum of the world's major industrialized economies), and UN General Assembly sessions function like religious ceremonies — regular, symbolic gatherings that reaffirm shared belief in "development," regardless of concrete outcomes.

Modern Sorcerers: Rist compares today's economic experts and forecasters to two historical/ethnographic examples of ritual prediction: **haruspices** — ancient Roman religious officials who claimed to foretell the future by examining the entrails (internal organs) of sacrificed animals — and the **Azande** oracles/sorcery practices — the Azande are a Central African people (in present-day South Sudan/DR Congo) whose belief systems around witchcraft and oracles were famously studied by the anthropologist E. E. Evans-Pritchard. In both historical cases, when a prediction failed, believers didn't conclude the *method* was flawed — they blamed a technical error (a badly performed ritual, bad luck) and tried again. Rist argues modern economic forecasting works the same way: when growth predictions or policy interventions fail, the system itself is never

blamed — the failure is attributed to "faulty data" or "poor execution," and the same approach is simply repeated.

Edgar Morin's "Defense of Belief": Edgar Morin is a French philosopher and sociologist known for work on complexity and belief systems. His idea, as used by Rist: people cling to the core belief in development at almost any cost because of a deep **fear of emptiness** — the psychological terror of admitting that decades of personal and national struggle, hope, and sacrifice might have been built on an illusion. It's psychologically easier to keep believing than to confront that possibility.

High-Yield Summary Table (Rist)

Concept	Conventional / Believer View	Sociological / Critical View (Rist)
Nature of Definition	Normative — desirable goals (well-being, democracy, human rights)	Descriptive — based on observable external practices
Environment	A pool of resources to manage for long-term growth	Inevitable destruction and entropic degradation driven by industrial energy use
Social Relations	Community empowerment, expanded choices, personal growth	Disintegration of kinship/gift bonds; total commodification and wage labor
Failures in Practice	Temporary errors from bad policy — fixable with better experts/aid	Structural features of a secular faith immune to being disproven

PART 2 — Wolfgang Sachs: Introduction to *The Development Dictionary*

0. Who and what

Wolfgang Sachs is a German social scientist who edited **The Development Dictionary** (first published 1992), a landmark collection of essays that helped launch the **post-development** school of thought (explained below). In this introduction, Sachs declares the official **"age of development"** — roughly 1949 to the early 1990s — dead, and says it's time to "write its obituary" (i.e., formally acknowledge it's over, the way you'd write an obituary for a deceased person). Rather than treating development's failure as merely technical or economic, Sachs frames development as **a particular cast of mind, myth, and perception** — that is, not just a set of policies, but a whole *way of seeing the world* that organized global relations after WWII and spread a Western worldview globally.

1. The Metaphor of the "Lighthouse" and Post-War Emergence

The Beacon on the Hill: After WWII, the old European colonial empires collapsed, and the **United States** stepped in to position itself as the new global leader, offering a vision of progress the whole

world could supposedly aspire to.

The Lighthouse Metaphor: A **lighthouse** guides ships safely toward shore by showing them a fixed point of light to steer by. Sachs uses this as a metaphor: "development" functioned as a guiding beacon that newly independent, post-colonial nations oriented themselves toward — regardless of whether they were democracies or dictatorships, "becoming developed" was treated as the shared, unquestioned goal.

The Broken Promise: Decades later, that promised destination never arrived — it keeps "receding into the dark," always just out of reach. Sachs says the lighthouse itself has now cracked and become a **"ruin in the intellectual landscape"** — i.e., the whole framework of belief around development has crumbled, even if people haven't fully admitted it yet.

Birth Date: Sachs pins the exact start of this era to **20 January 1949**, when U.S. President **Harry S. Truman** delivered his inaugural address. Its fourth policy proposal — known as **"Point Four"** — proposed technical assistance for poorer nations, and in doing so, labeled the entire Southern hemisphere as **"underdeveloped areas."** This single phrase created a whole new mental framework: it cast rich nations as naturally positioned to help ("Northern interventionism") and poor nations as naturally lacking and in need of rescue ("Southern self-pity") — a framing that didn't exist in quite this form before.

2. The Four Collapsed Founding Premises

Sachs argues the entire "age of development" rested on four historical assumptions — all of which have since fallen apart:

Premise 1: The Ecological Predicament (Superiority Shattered)

Old premise: Industrialized nations (led by the U.S.) sat at the top of an assumed ladder of social/technological progress ("social evolutionism" again — see Part 1), and continued technological advancement would eventually free all of humanity from hard physical labor.

Reality: This model turns out to be **ecologically unviable** (impossible to sustain without destroying the environment it depends on). Humanity now consumes, in a single year, natural resources that took the Earth roughly a million years to form (fossil fuels), leaving behind scarred landscapes and polluted air.

The "Five or Six Planets" Problem: If every country on Earth reached the same level of industrial resource consumption as wealthy Northern nations, calculations suggest it would take the mining and waste-absorbing capacity of five or six planet Earths to sustain it. In other words, the "advanced" Western lifestyle isn't a viable universal model — it's only possible *because* most of the world hasn't (yet) copied it; it's an exception, not a template.

Premise 2: Geopolitics and the End of the Cold War

Old premise: Truman originally launched global development partly as a Cold War strategy — the **Cold War** was the decades-long ideological/geopolitical standoff (1947–1991) between the U.S.-led capitalist bloc and the USSR-led communist bloc. Offering "development" aid was a way to win the political loyalty of newly independent countries away from Soviet communism.

Reality: Once the Cold War ended (around 1991), development lost its main political motive, and the old label **"Third World"** (a Cold War term for countries aligned with neither the capitalist "First

World" nor the communist "Second World" — mostly newly independent nations in Africa, Asia, and Latin America) stopped making analytical sense.

Shift to Risk Management: Instead of promising an "industrial paradise" and redistributing wealth, contemporary development policy has shifted toward **prevention and risk containment** — i.e., managing dangers to the wealthy world, such as halting refugee flows, preventing regional wars from spreading, curbing illegal trade, and containing environmental damage — a much more defensive, self-interested posture than the original promise.

Premise 3: The Widening Gap and Social Polarization

Old premise: Poorer "Southern" countries could gradually "catch up" to the wealthy "North" simply through economic growth.

Reality: Instead, the gap widened dramatically — in 1960, Northern countries were about **20 times richer** than Southern countries; by 1980, they were **46 times richer**.

Competitive Obsolescence: The North keeps accelerating its own technology and productivity, so the target the South is chasing keeps moving further away — Sachs compares this to the Aztec emperor **Montezuma's** fatal mistake in welcoming the Spanish conquistador **Hernán Cortés** as a returning god rather than recognizing the real, existential threat he posed — a metaphor for naively trusting a system that will ultimately overpower you.

Internal Polarization: Development dismantled traditional safety nets (kinship networks, subsistence farming, mutual aid) without successfully replacing them with viable modern alternatives, leaving many people stranded in a **"no-man's-land between tradition and modernity"** — e.g., peasant farmers who can no longer afford the expensive hybrid seeds that modern agriculture pushed them toward, workers laid off from jobs that development created and then eliminated, and mothers left economically marginalized as older support structures broke down.

Premise 4: Cultural Monoculture and Westernization

Old premise: All human societies were assumed to be traveling along one single, linear path toward maturity — with the modern West as the finished example everyone else was still working toward. Diverse cultures (Sachs names the **Tuareg** — nomadic Saharan people, the **Zapotec** — an Indigenous people of southern Mexico, and **Rajasthanis** — people of the Rajasthan region of India) were treated not as legitimately different ways of life, but as incomplete, "backward" versions of the modern West.

Reality: Development functioned as a covert (hidden, not openly stated) campaign for the **Westernization** of the entire world — spreading Western institutions, technology, and values everywhere under the neutral-sounding banner of "progress."

Erosion of Diversity: This process replaced diverse languages, customs, architectural styles, and ways of imagining life with what Sachs calls a **"cultural monoculture."** (**Monoculture** is originally an agricultural term — planting a single crop across a vast area instead of many different ones, which increases yield short-term but destroys biodiversity and resilience; Sachs applies the same idea to global culture.) This monoculture is driven by the standardizing forces of markets, nation-states, and Western science.

3. Development as an "Amoeba-like Concept"

An **amoeba** is a single-celled microorganism with no fixed, rigid shape — it constantly reshapes itself as it moves and feeds. Sachs uses this as a metaphor: decades after Truman's speech, "development" has become a **shapeless, amoeba-like term** — its actual, concrete content has become almost meaningless (it can't tell you precisely what's being done), yet it still *connotes* (suggests, carries the emotional association of) good intentions, which makes it almost impossible to directly criticize or challenge. It has become a **universal banner** — invoked equally by completely opposed actors: the **IMF** (International Monetary Fund, a global financial institution) *and* the Vatican, armed revolutionaries *and* briefcase-carrying UN bureaucrats, right-wing *and* left-wing political elites. Because it sounds automatically good, "development" can be used to justify almost any intervention, from any political direction, under the guise of serving a higher moral goal.

4. Purpose of the Book & Key Influences

Discourse Analysis & "Archaeology of Concepts": **Discourse analysis** is a method (strongly associated with the French philosopher **Michel Foucault**) for studying how language and ways of talking about a topic actively shape what we perceive as reality — and how that language is tied to power (who gets to define terms, and who that definition benefits). **"Archaeology of concepts"** is a term borrowed from Foucault's book *The Archaeology of Knowledge* — the idea of "digging" beneath a familiar word to uncover its buried historical origins and hidden assumptions, much like an archaeologist digs beneath the surface to find older layers. Sachs's book applies this method to central Western-rooted concepts that make up the "developmental matrix" — words like **poverty**, **production**, **state**, and **equality** — treating even these seemingly neutral, universal-sounding words as historically specific inventions that carry hidden Western assumptions.

Goal: To dismantle the mental framework that professional "development experts" operate within, to empower grassroots (locally-organized, bottom-up rather than top-down) alternatives, and to encourage what Sachs calls an **"apostasy from the faith in development."** (**Apostasy** is originally a religious term for abandoning one's faith — used metaphorically here to mean abandoning belief in development as a project, reinforcing Rist's "secular religion" framing from Part 1.) The larger aim is to clear intellectual space for a **post-development** era — a school of thought holding that "development" isn't a project that needs fixing or reforming, but one that should be abandoned altogether in favor of plural, locally-rooted visions of a good life.

Key Influence: The book was conceived collaboratively, born out of long debates among its contributors, and was deeply shaped by the thinking and personal influence of **Ivan Illich** (1926–2002) — an Austrian-born philosopher and radical social critic famous for sweeping critiques of modern institutions, including formal schooling (*Deschooling Society*) and institutionalized medicine — a major intellectual forerunner of the post-development school.

Quick Comparison: Sachs vs. Rist (Exam-Ready)

Dimension	Wolfgang Sachs (<i>Introduction</i>)	Gilbert Rist (<i>Definitions of Development</i>)
Historical Starting Point	20 January 1949 — Truman's inaugural address / Point Four	The Industrial Revolution and the rise of the market economy
Primary Framing	A crumbling myth/lighthouse and a failed cultural monoculture project	A secular religion backed by entropic, destructive real-world practices
Ecological Critique	"Five or six planets" would be needed to sustain worldwide industrialization at Northern levels	Production is inherently entropic — an irreversible, one-way consumption of energy and nature
Central Metaphor	The lighthouse (guiding beacon that turned out to be a ruin); the amoeba (shapeless, ever-adaptable concept)	The secular religion (dogma, rituals, "modern sorcerers" who never take the blame for failed predictions)
Call to Action	Intellectual "apostasy"; dismantling development jargon to reclaim cultural diversity; post-development	Sociological deconstruction of development's practices and unexamined sacred beliefs

Master Glossary (Quick Revision)

Term	Plain-Language Definition
Sociology	The scientific/systematic study of society, institutions, and collective human behavior
Émile Durkheim	Founding figure of academic sociology; insisted social facts be studied objectively, like natural-science "things"
Positivism / Empirical method	Building knowledge strictly from observable, verifiable evidence, not opinion or ideology
Secular religion	A belief system that behaves like a religion (dogma, ritual, unquestionable faith) despite claiming to be non-religious/rational
Entropy / Entropic	(From physics) The tendency of ordered energy/resources to irreversibly degrade into disorder/waste/heat
Commodification	Turning something (labor, nature, relationships) into a tradeable, priced object bought and sold in a market

Term	Plain-Language Definition
Social evolutionism	The (flawed) idea that societies pass through fixed stages from "primitive" to "advanced," with the West at the top
Individualism (as critique)	Framing the individual person, rather than the community, as the basic unit whose "potential" needs developing
Economism	Reducing "progress" mainly or solely to economic growth/income
Normative vs. Descriptive	Normative = what <i>ought</i> to be (a value judgment); Descriptive = what actually <i>is</i> (an observation)
Intensifiers	Words like "more"/"better" that imply comparison/lack rather than describing a fixed, observable state
Portmanteau word	A word blending multiple meanings into one (e.g., "smog")
Plastic words (Pörksen)	Authoritative-sounding but vague words stretchable to justify almost anything
Endogenous	Arising from within a system/society itself, rather than imposed from outside
Wage labor	Work performed for money paid by an employer
Commodity exchange	A system where goods/services are bought/sold in a market at a price
Kinship / Reciprocity	Family/clan bonds and mutual, non-monetary exchange of help and goods
Adam Smith	18th-century economist; described markets as running on self-interest, not benevolence
Externality	A cost (e.g., pollution) that falls outside a system's accounting and isn't directly paid for
Effective demand	Demand backed by actual purchasing power (money), as opposed to mere need
Intertemporality problem	Future generations can't participate in today's markets, so resources get used up without regard for them
Ideology	A debatable political/economic belief system people can openly disagree with
Collective certainty / Dogma	A belief treated as beyond question, like religious faith
Floating propositions	Widely repeated claims accepted as true without real proof

Term	Plain-Language Definition
Haruspices	Ancient Roman officials who predicted the future from animal entrails
Azande	A Central African people whose oracle/witchcraft beliefs were studied by anthropologist E. E. Evans-Pritchard; used as a comparison for modern "expert" forecasting
Edgar Morin	French philosopher/sociologist; theorized why people cling to belief despite repeated failure
Wolfgang Sachs	Editor of <i>The Development Dictionary</i> ; declared the "age of development" over
Point Four / Truman	The 1949 speech proposal that coined "underdeveloped areas" and is treated as the start of the development era
Third World	Cold War-era term for non-aligned, newly independent nations (neither U.S.-led nor USSR-led bloc)
Cold War	1947–1991 ideological/geopolitical standoff between the U.S. and USSR blocs
Cultural monoculture	(From agriculture) The replacement of diverse cultures with one standardized (Western) model
Amoeba-like concept	A term (like "development") so shapeless and stretchable it can mean almost anything
Discourse analysis	Studying how language shapes perceived reality and is tied to power (associated with Michel Foucault)
Archaeology of concepts	Digging into the hidden historical origins/assumptions behind familiar words (Foucault)
Post-development	The view that "development" should be abandoned, not reformed, in favor of plural local alternatives
Apostasy	Originally: abandoning religious faith. Here: abandoning belief in development
Ivan Illich	Radical philosopher/critic of modern institutions; major influence on post-development thought

These notes expand and explain — for a technical/non-arts reader — the summary content in the uploaded PDF, covering Gilbert Rist's Ch. 1 and Wolfgang Sachs's Introduction to The Development Dictionary.